3.3 The Southern Colonies

Have you ever made a plan that didn't work out as you expected? Leaders developed detailed plans for the Southern Colonies. But as more colonists arrived, some of the plans worked better than others.

MAIN IDEA The Southern Colonies provided economic opportunities and social challenges for the colonists who settled in them.

COLONIAL EXPANSION AND COMMERCE

As you have read, in 1607 Jamestown became the first colonial settlement. In 1699, Williamsburg became the new capital of the Virginia colony. Over time, Europeans established settlements in many parts of the South. Maryland, Virginia, North Carolina, South Carolina, and Georgia together formed the **Southern Colonies**.

In 1632, King Charles I of England granted a charter to George Calvert, who held the title Lord Baltimore, to establish a new colony called Maryland, made up of the northern part of Virginia. Most of its settlers were small landowners and renters. Upon Calvert's untimely death, his son became Lord Baltimore and Maryland's **proprietor**—the person responsible for the colony. Maryland's location on the Chesapeake Bay provided easy access to trade, and the region's rich, fertile soil was ideal for growing tobacco. Wealthy plantation owners and merchants built docks on **tributaries**, or small rivers that flow into larger bodies of water, of the Chesapeake Bay. There, they could more easily load ships with tobacco for export and receive ships from around the world loaded with goods.

By 1670, Carolina had become a colony. By 1691, it had split into two colonies: North Carolina, already settled by small planters from Virginia, and South Carolina. Many of South Carolina's settlers came from Barbados in the West Indies. They established large plantations where they grew tobacco, rice, cotton, sugarcane, and other crops. They purchased enslaved Africans to work these plantations. By 1729, both Carolinas had become **royal colonies**, or colonies with a governor and council appointed by the king.



GEORGIA: A GRAND EXPERIMENT FAILS

Most of Britain's American colonies were founded for profit or religious freedom. But Georgia, the last mainland British colony in North America, began with a different idea. **James Oglethorpe** and Viscount John Percival envisioned a colony in which debtors and the very poor could make a new start.

King George II wasn't interested in helping the poor, but he understood that Georgia could be a military buffer between Spanish Florida and South Carolina. He granted the charter, placing control of the colony in the hands of trustees who could neither receive financial gain from Georgia nor own

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CRITICAL VIEWING Tobacco was one of the major crops in the Southern Colonies. Today, the work of planting, harvesting, and preparing tobacco for market is much the same as it was during the colonial period. In the top photo, a man in Tennessee harvests the whole tobacco plant by chopping it at its base. In the bottom photo, bundles of tobacco hang to cure, or dry and preserve. Based on details you notice in both photos, what kinds of challenges do you think tobacco farmers encounter?

land within it. As governor, Oglethorpe required that all colonists follow three rules based on his own beliefs: no slaves, no liquor, and limited land ownership for each settler. His lofty vision did not last long.

Settlers began arriving in 1733. Many of them found the colony's strict policies unreasonable, so Georgia's population grew slowly. Its role as military buffer between the Spanish and British colonies soon became a source of conflict. The Spanish, suspecting the British of smuggling slaves and goods into Spanish provinces, began searching British ships. Then, in 1740, Oglethorpe attacked Florida, in an attempt to drive the Spanish out. The Spanish, in turn, invaded Georgia in 1742. After a number of other conflicts, both sides gave up, and calm was restored to the buffer zone.

The trustees recognized that Georgia would not thrive under Oglethorpe's strict rules. By 1750, laws allowed liquor and slavery, and there were no limits on land ownership. In 1752, control of Georgia returned to Great Britain. The grand experiment had failed.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** In what ways was Georgia different from the other Southern Colonies?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why might James Oglethorpe have insisted on limiting the amount of land a settler could have?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** Find the city of Charleston on the map. What advantages do you think this city enjoyed due to its geographic location?

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